

I know this sounds like a no-brainer, but if you have the chance to go generic, you should seriously consider it. Generic drugs are considerably cheaper than brand-name, and there's a very good chance it won't affect you any differently than the more expensive brand.

In fact, many doctors assure their patients that it *is* the same, but I actually interviewed a pharmacy tech for a magazine article once, and she helped me understand that it's not always that simple. While the drug is essentially the same, they each carry fillers that react differently depending on your particular genetic makeup.

This is why after reading multiple reviews on how the generic version of my prescription affected everyone in different ways, I chose to stick with the brand-name until I didn't need it anymore. Would the generic have affected me any differently? I can't say for sure, but that decision is for people to decide for themselves. Do your research, consider the costs (and alternatives), and make the best decision for you!

5. USE A MAIL-ORDER PHARMACY

For insurance holders, a three-month supply of prescriptions ordered through a mail-order pharmacy is convenient and saves a ton of money. Because the pharmacy only dispenses the medication once, rather than three or more times, you're charged a lower copay. And most refills are simple to do online.

Here's the thing, though...you need to plan for mail-order drugs. If you order them too early, insurance won't pay for them and the online pharmacy won't give any out. But, if you wait too long, you might not receive the meds in time. Some take only a few days to send, while others can take up to two weeks. Mark your calendar so you know exactly when to order!

Check online sites like HealthWarehouse.com and FamilyMeds.com just to see if their prices are any lower. And for those who are intrigued by the "black market," I can tell you that I've had friends order their scripts from Canada with no problems, but you do have to be careful. It's harder to know which companies are legal, and which medications are truly authentic.